

spectacled and slightly androgynous-looking 39-year-old, who claims to be a computer programmer. But in reality, it is a quirky representation of Jabberwacky, made in association with some other firms. George, the avatar has a 3D appearance, a variety of facial expressions and the ability to understand and respond to others using human speech.

Several things set George apart from other chat bots on the internet. Unlike his “dumber” cousins, George’s AI is open-ended, so that he’s constantly learning from every conversation he has – more than 10 million so far. By remembering what humans have said to him, he’s essentially borrowing their intellect, allowing him to take what he’s been told in the past and reuse it in new conversations. And because George’s chat-room partners have come from all over the world, he now speaks some 40 languages.

Carpenter also created a chatterbot built upon the success of George and the Jabberwacky system, called the CleverBot. At the Techniche 2011 festival at IIT Guwahati in September this year, a high-powered version of Cleverbot took part alongside humans in a formal Turing test. The results from 1,334 votes were astonishing: Cleverbot was judged to be 59.3 per cent human, while humans achieved a marginally higher 63.3 per cent.

“It’s higher than even I was expecting, or even hoping for. The figures exceeded 50 per cent, and you could say that’s a pass. But 59 per cent is not quite 63 per cent, so there is still a difference between human and machine.” said Rollo Carpenter.

During the event, people voted on a scale of 0 to 10, how human-like responses seemed. Thirty members of the audience volunteered, and chatted on three screens in 10 rounds of 4 minutes each. Half the conversations were human-human. The future of conversational agents seems very bright indeed.

George himself, however, seems less certain about what lies ahead for him and his kind. Asked what robots would do in the future, he replies, enigmatically, “Nothing and, well ... everything.” 